

READING EDITION

My Dear Beloved Son or Daughter (Ayyuhal Walad)

A Letter Across the Centuries

Centuries stand between us, and yet here you are, holding these words in your hands. That alone is a small wonder worth pausing over. A young man once sat in my circles for years. He learned what I had to teach — the disciplines, the proofs, the careful divisions of the sciences — and he gave of himself generously to acquire it all. Then one night a question settled on him that he could not shake loose, and he wrote it down and sent it to me. Of everything I labored to learn, he asked, which of it will actually help me? Which knowledge will light my grave when I am laid in it? Which will speak for me on the Day when speaking matters? And which of it — for all the years I spent — will turn out to have been weight without worth, so that I might lay it down now and walk lighter? He had not forgotten the Messenger of God, may God's peace and blessings be upon him, who said:

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنْ عِلْمٍ لَا يَنْفَعُ

"I seek refuge in God from knowledge that does not benefit."

He turned that prayer over in his chest for days before he wrote to me. He knew I had already written, at length, on these very questions. He had read the *Ihya Ulum al-Din* — the Revival of the Religious Sciences — and the *Kimiya al-Sa'ada*, the Alchemy of Happiness, and the *Jawahir al-Qur'an*, those gems of the Book; he knew the *Arba'in*, the Forty Principles, and the *Minhaj al-Abidin*, the Worshippers Road to the Paradise of the Lord of the Worlds. He had read more than enough. What he wanted now was something smaller, something he could keep on his person and live by — a few pages he could return to in the morning and act upon by

night. He asked, too, for counsel he could carry, and a prayer he could say at any hour. So I wrote him this letter. I did not write a treatise. I wrote what I would say to him if he were sitting across from me, and I wrote it knowing that whoever else needed it would also, in time, find their way to it.

That is how this letter reaches you. You are the walad now — the son, the student, the one I am addressing. Read it slowly. Read it as if it were written this morning, because in everything that matters, it was.

1. Knowledge That Will Not Save You

My dear son, my true friend — may God lengthen your life in His worship, and set your feet on the road His beloveds walked. Before I say anything else, hear this: the wellspring of every counsel worth giving is the living presence of the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him. Every honest word of guidance rests on his sayings and his way — his outward conduct and his inward state both. Counsel that runs against his teaching benefits no one. Whole libraries of advice have already been drawn from the light of his hadith and his sunnah. If those have reached you, you need nothing from me. But if they have not — if after all this you remain untouched by them — then tell me honestly: in all the years you sat with me, what is it you actually learned?

Among the counsels of the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, is this:

عَلَامَةٌ إِعْرَاضِ اللَّهِ عَنِ الْعَبْدِ اشْتِغَالُهُ بِمَا لَا يَغْنِيهِ، وَإِنَّ أَمْرًا ذَهَبَتْ سَاعَةٌ
مِنْ عُمرِهِ فِي غَيْرِ مَا خُلِقَ لَهُ لَحَرِيٍّ أَنْ تَطُولَ عَلَيْهِ حَسْرَتُهُ

"A servant's preoccupation with what does not concern him is a sign that God has turned His special favor away from him. And if even a single hour of a man's life passes in pursuit of something other than that for which he was created, he is fit to grieve long over it."

And he said, peace and blessings be upon him:

مَنْ جَاوَزَ الْأَرْبَعِينَ سَنَةً وَلَمْ يَغْلِبْ خَيْرُهُ عَلَى شَرِّهِ فَلْيَتَّجِهْ إِلَى النَّارِ

"Whoever passes forty years and the good in him has not overcome the evil — let him prepare himself for the Fire."

It is easy, my son, to recite such counsel to the whole world. It is brutally hard to act on it oneself. Anyone whose heart is occupied by the pleasures of this world and the cravings of the lower self finds this kind of speech bitter on the tongue. Their hearts are tangled in appetite. And of all such people, the one I most want you to recognize is this: the man who has acquired philosophy and the sciences and the polished learning of the age, and then quietly persuades himself that this knowledge alone will be his rescue in the Hereafter — and his fame and standing in this world along the way. He concludes, without ever admitting it openly, that the labor of *acting* on what he knows does not apply to him. He is exempt. This delusion is the particular sickness of those who study philosophy and nothing else. Glory be to God, the Great — such a man does not even suspect that the very knowledge he refused to live by will

rise against him on the Day of Judgment as the instrument of his punishment. Has he never heard the words of the Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him?

إِنَّ أَشَدَّ النَّاسِ عَذَابًا يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ عَالِمٌ لَمْ يَنْفَعَهُ اللَّهُ بِعِلْمِهِ

"The most severely punished of people on the Day of Judgment will be a scholar whom God did not benefit through his knowledge."

That is, one who did not act upon what he learned.

In the accounts of God's intimate friends, it is told that a certain saint saw Shaykh Junayd of Baghdad, may God have mercy on him, in a dream after his death, and asked him: "Abu al-Qasim — tell me, what was it like, after?"

And Junayd answered him: "All the discourses, all the subtle spiritual indications — every one of them came to nothing. The only thing that helped me was a few cycles of prayer I used to perform in the depth of the night."

So, my son: do not strip yourself of righteous deeds. Do not abandon the knowledge of the outward law. And do not let yourself live without the inner excellences, the noble qualities of the heart. Settle this in your bones — knowledge without deeds will not save you on the Day of Judgment.

Picture a man walking through a wilderness, armed to the teeth — ten sharpened swords at his belt, a fine bow on his back, every other weapon you can name, and a complete mastery of the science of war and how each weapon is to be used. A lion appears in his path. Tell me: can he survive without ever drawing a single blade? You know he cannot. It is

exactly the same with you. A man can master a hundred thousand questions of jurisprudence; if he does not act on a single one of them, the knowledge will not save him.

Or take a sick man who knows precisely which medicines would cure him — knows their names, their preparations, their properties down to the smallest detail — and never swallows a drop. Will the knowledge of the cure cure him? You can see the answer with your own eyes. The mere knowing of a remedy does nothing to heal the diseases of the soul. A poet put it this way: you may buy two thousand pounds of wine, but you will not be drunk until you actually drink.

Hoarding knowledge, leafing endlessly through book after book, and never acting on any of it will gain you nothing — until you make yourself worthy of God's mercy through righteous works. Until then, His grace stays at a distance from you. Hear what the Qur'an itself says:

وَأَنْ لَّيْسَ لِلْإِنْسَانِ إِلَّا مَا سَعَىٰ

"And that man shall have nothing but that for which he strives."
(Qur'an 53:39)

This settles it: a human being attains success only through real, sustained striving. Now, my son, I know what you have read — that some have said this verse was abrogated. Let us grant it for the sake of argument. What then will you say about these:

فَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ مِثْقَالَ ذَرَّةٍ خَيْرًا يَرَهُ ۖ وَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ مِثْقَالَ ذَرَّةٍ شَرًّا يَرَهُ

"So whoever does an atom's weight of good shall see it, and whoever does an atom's weight of evil shall see it." (Qur'an 99:7–8)

فَمَنْ كَانَ يَرْجُو لِقَاءَ رَبِّهِ فَلْيَعْمَلْ عَمَلًا صَالِحًا وَلَا يُشْرِكْ بِعِبَادَةِ رَبِّهِ أَحَدًا

"So whoever hopes for the meeting with his Lord — let him do righteous work and not associate anyone in the worship of his Lord." (Qur'an 18:110)

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحَاتِ كَانَتْ لَهُمْ جَنَّاتُ الْفِرْدَوْسِ نُزُلًا
خَالِدِينَ فِيهَا

"Truly those who have believed and done righteous deeds — the Gardens of Paradise will be their lodging. They will abide therein forever." (Qur'an 18:107–108)

And in another place He, Exalted is He, has said:

إِلَّا مَنْ تَابَ وَآمَنَ وَعَمِلَ عَمَلًا صَالِحًا

"Except for the one who repents, believes, and does righteous work." (Qur'an 25:70)

And what will you say about the noble hadith of the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him?

بُنِيَ الْإِسْلَامُ عَلَى خَمْسٍ: شَهَادَةِ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ وَأَنَّ مُحَمَّدًا رَسُولُ اللَّهِ، وَإِقَامِ الصَّلَاةِ، وَإِيتَاءِ الزَّكَاةِ، وَصَوْمِ شَهْرِ رَمَضَانَ، وَحَجِّ الْبَيْتِ مَنْ اسْتَطَاعَ إِلَيْهِ سَبِيلًا

"Islam is built upon five: to testify that there is no god but God and that Muhammad is the Messenger of God, to establish the prayer, to give the zakat, to fast in the month of Ramadan, and to perform the pilgrimage to the House for whoever is able to find a way to it."

الْإِيمَانُ إِقْرَارٌ بِاللِّسَانِ وَتَصَدِيقٌ بِالْجَنَانِ وَعَمَلٌ بِالْأَرْكَانِ

"Faith is affirmation with the tongue, acknowledgement in the heart, and action with the limbs."

Now — and this is delicate, so listen — if after all this a quiet thought begins to form in your heart that I am telling you a servant enters Paradise by his own deeds and not by God's grace, then you have misread me entirely. I am saying the opposite. A servant enters Paradise by the favor, the generosity, the kindness of God. But until that servant makes himself worthy of mercy through worship and obedience, he is in no condition to receive it. This is not my private opinion. It is God Himself, Exalted is He, who says:

إِنَّ رَحْمَتَ اللَّهِ قَرِيبٌ مِنَ الْمُحْسِنِينَ

"Truly the mercy of God is near to those who do good." (Qur'an 7:56)

So how, then, will a servant enter Paradise without the mercy of God? I will say it again, because everything turns on it: how will a servant enter Paradise without the mercy of God?

And if someone wants to argue back at me that faith alone, all by itself, will be enough to carry him in — let him remember that between him and that gate lie many fearful valleys, many steep passes. And the first of them, and the most terrifying of all, is this: to carry your faith, intact, all the way to the end.

2. The Striving That Mercy Meets

And so the question stands before us like a mountain we cannot walk around: if even faith requires mercy to carry it across, then what of works? My dear son, settle this in your heart once and for all — without striving, there is no reward to receive. The two are not separable. Mercy is not a substitute for effort; it is what answers effort when effort has done all it can.

Let me tell you a story that has stayed with me, because it cuts to the bone of what I am trying to say.

Among the Children of Israel there was a man who worshipped God with a devotion that would shame most of us into silence. God, in His wisdom, sent an angel to test him. The angel came to him and delivered a message that would have broken almost anyone: "God, the Holy, says that you have been tormenting yourself to no purpose. Your worship is not accepted. You will go to Hell."

Imagine receiving such a sentence after a lifetime on your knees. Imagine the cold that would enter the chest. And yet listen to what this man said in reply: "God, the Exalted, created us for His worship and His service.

Our duty is to serve Him — no matter what comes. He is the Owner of all things and all people, myself among them, and He is the All-Powerful."

He did not bargain. He did not protest. He did not stop. He simply returned to the only posture a servant has ever truly owned: I am His, whether He keeps me or casts me away.

The angel returned to the Presence and said, "O my Lord, You are the Knower of every secret in this universe, and You know what Your worshipping servant has answered." And God, the Exalted, said: "Since this servant of Ours does not turn his face away from Our worship and Our service, We too will not turn Our Face away from him."

أَشْهَدُكُمْ يَا مَلَائِكَتِي أَنِّي قَدْ غَفَرْتُ لَهُ

"O My angels, bear witness — all of you — that I have forgiven him."

Do you see what passed there? The man did not earn forgiveness by his works alone; he earned it by refusing to abandon the posture of a servant even when the worst news a servant can hear was placed in his hands. The works were the ground; the unbroken facing was the offering; mercy was the answer. Remove any of the three and the whole collapses.

So now, while you still have breath in your body and your accounts are still open, hear what the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him, says:

حَاسِبُوا قَبْلَ أَنْ تُحَاسَبُوا، وَزِنُوا قَبْلَ أَنْ تُوزَنُوا

"Take account of yourselves before you are taken to account, and weigh your deeds before your deeds are weighed."

That is, examine your works critically while there is still time to correct what is crooked in them — before the Day when the weighing is no longer in your hands, when the scale is set up and the verdict is decreed and there is no going back to fix the small thing you knew you ought to fix.

And lest you misunderstand and slide into the opposite ditch, hear what Ali, may God honor his countenance, said:

مَنْ ظَنَّ أَنَّهُ بِدُونِ الْجُهْدِ يَصِلُ فَهُوَ مُتَمَنَّ، وَمَنْ ظَنَّ أَنَّهُ بِبَذْلِ الْجُهْدِ يَصِلُ فَهُوَ مُتْعَبٌ

"Whoever supposes he will arrive without striving is merely wishing; and whoever supposes he will arrive by his striving alone is merely exhausting himself."

Read that twice and let it settle. There are two ditches on either side of this road, and most travellers fall into one or the other. On one side is the man who thinks Paradise will be handed to him because he loves God in his heart and means well — the wisher, the daydreamer. On the other side is the man who thinks his prayers and his fasts and his vigils have built him a ladder he can climb on his own strength — the self-exhauster, who is so impressed by his own climbing that he forgets Whose hand alone can pull him up at the top. Both are mistaken. The

road runs between them. Strive as if everything depends on you; rely as if nothing does.

Shaykh Hasan al-Basri, may God shower His mercy upon him, put it with the bluntness only he could manage:

طَلَبُ الْجَنَّةِ بِلَا عَمَلٍ ذَنْبٌ مِنَ الذُّنُوبِ

"To desire Paradise without works is itself a sin among the sins."

Sit with that. Wanting Paradise while doing nothing for it is not innocent — it is a kind of impudence. It is to think that the King's house will open its doors for a guest who could not be bothered to walk to the threshold.

And another of God's intimates said something so subtle that you must read it slowly:

الْحَقِيقَةُ تَرْكُ مِلَاحَظَةِ الْعَمَلِ لَا تَرْكُ الْعَمَلِ

"The reality is to leave off admiring your works — not to leave off the works themselves."

Do you hear the precision? The danger of self-admiration is real; the answer is not to stop acting. The answer is to keep acting and to stop watching yourself act. Stop holding up a mirror to your own piety. Pray, give, fast, study, serve — and then forget that you did, the way the hand forgets the bread it just gave away.

And our master in both worlds, the Prophet Muhammad, may God's peace and blessings be upon him, said it more clearly, more cleanly, more beautifully than any tongue before or after:

الْكَيْسُ مَنْ دَانَ نَفْسَهُ وَعَمِلَ لِمَا بَعْدَ الْمَوْتِ، وَالْأَحْمَقُ مَنْ اتَّبَعَ نَفْسَهُ هَوَاهَا
وَتَمَنَّى عَلَى اللَّهِ

"Intelligent is the one who subdues his lower self and works for what comes after death. Foolish is the one who follows his lower self's appetites and yet presumes upon God."

In another narration the closing phrase is *وَتَمَنَّى عَلَى اللَّهِ الْمَغْفِرَةَ* — "and presumes upon God for forgiveness." That is the whole syllabus of the religion in a single sentence. Intelligence is not what you thought it was when you were a student showing off in a circle. Intelligence is to bring your own self to heel and to invest your days in what survives the grave. And foolishness — real, dangerous foolishness — is to let your appetites lead you anywhere they please, and then to say, in the soft voice we all use when we are deceiving ourselves, "God is merciful. He will forgive me."

He is merciful. That is precisely why you cannot insult His mercy by treating it as a license.

Now I want to ask you something directly, because I have known you, and I know how you have spent your nights. You have stayed awake when others were sleeping. You have rehearsed your books and memorized your texts and pushed the hours into the small ones. The lamp has burned for you when it has gone out for your neighbors. Good. But for whose face have you done it?

If your intention in all of this — in the wakefulness, in the memorizing, in the sacrifice of sleep — was to gain a place in the world, a reputation, a salary, the deference of students, the satisfaction of being the one who knew the answer when others did not — then:

فَوَيْلٌ لَّكَ تُمْ وَيْلٌ لَّكَ

"Woe unto you, and again woe unto you."

I do not say this to wound you. I say it because the wound, taken now, is a kindness compared to the wound delayed.

But if your intention in all of this was to plant the way of God in yourself first, and then in others — the way brought by the Prophet, may peace and blessings be upon him — if it was to lift your character and your community, to drive out from your soul the evil that lives in every soul until it is driven out — then:

فَطُوبَى لَّكَ تُمْ طُوبَى لَّكَ

"Blessed are you, and again blessed are you."

The same hours of study; the same loss of sleep; the same texts memorized — and yet two utterly different destinies, separated only by the small invisible thing that lives behind your eyes when you sit down to read. Intention. Always intention.

And here, because there are nights on this road where the heart is heavier than language can carry, I want to leave you with a couplet that has often risen to my lips in the dark:

سَهَرُ الْعُيُونِ بِغَيْرِ وَجْهِكَ ضَائِعٌ

وَبُكَاءُهُنَّ بِغَيْرِ فَقْدِكَ بَاطِلٌ

"The wakefulness of the eyes, except for the sight of Your Face, is wasted. And the weeping of the eyes, except in grief for losing You, is in vain."

Let those two lines settle in you. Stay awake — but stay awake for Him. Weep — but weep for Him. Any other vigil is a lamp burning over an empty page; any other grief is a river running into sand.

And finally, hear the tradition that gathers all of this into a single closing breath:

عِشْ مَا شِئْتَ فَإِنَّكَ مَيِّتٌ، وَأَحِبِّ مَا شِئْتَ فَإِنَّكَ مُفَارِقُهُ، وَاعْمَلْ مَا شِئْتَ

فَإِنَّكَ مَجْزِيٌّ بِهِ

"Live as you wish — but know you will die. Love whomever you wish — but know you will be parted from them. Do whatever you wish — but know you will be repaid for it."

Three sentences. Three doors closing softly behind a life. Live — and die. Love — and lose. Act — and be answered. There is no fourth door. There is no exit at the side of the building. Every life that has ever been lived has passed through these three, and yours will pass through them too, on a date already written.

So strive, my son. Strive as one who knows that striving alone will not carry him, and that the absence of striving will leave him stranded. Work as though the work were everything; lean as though the leaning were

everything; and let the mercy of God meet you somewhere on the road between the two. That is where His mercy has always met His servants. That is where, if God wills, it will meet you.

3. The Hours Before Dawn

My beloved son, listen now to a different kind of question — one I want you to ask yourself before the sun rises tomorrow. What, in truth, have you gained for your own soul from all that you have studied? You have sat with theology and turned its arguments over in your mind. You have read ethics, and learned to name the virtues and the vices. You have looked into medicine, into the courses of the stars, into the niceties of language, into the meters of poetry, into the strategies of war. You have spent your nights bent over these books and your days speaking of them in gatherings. Tell me honestly: beyond a life that has slipped through your fingers and a name that flickers for a moment in the mouths of men, what have you truly carried away?

I once read in the Gospel of Isa, upon whom be the peace of God, that in the interval between the placing of a corpse in its bier and the lowering of that bier into the grave, God by His own power addresses the dead body with forty questions. The very first of them is this:

عَبْدِي، قَدْ تَطَهَّرْتَ مِنْ نَظَرِ الْخَلْقِ سِنِينَ، فَهَلْ تَطَهَّرْتَ مِنْ نَظَرِي سَاعَةً

"My slave — for years on end you beautified yourself with outward knowledge so that the eyes of My creation would look favorably upon you. But for My sake alone, did you ever purify your heart from heedlessness and from evil, even for a single hour?"

And remember what the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him, said in a sound tradition:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَنْظُرُ إِلَى صُورِكُمْ وَأَجْسَامِكُمْ، وَلَكِنْ يَنْظُرُ إِلَى قُلُوبِكُمْ

"God does not look at your faces or at your bodies; He looks at your hearts."

So nothing matters more than the purification of the heart, because the heart is the one thing held perpetually under the gaze of God.

My dear beloved son, every single day a voice from your Lord resounds in the chamber of your heart, and the voice says:

عَبْدِي، مَا تَصْنَعُ بِيْغَيْرِي وَأَنْتَ مَخْشُوفٌ بِخَيْرِي

"My slave — why do you perform your worship for show and reputation, when both your ease and your hardship rest in My hand alone? Worship Me with a pure intention, and not to impress any of My mortal creatures, who can neither benefit you nor harm you in the smallest measure except by My will."

Hear me clearly. Knowledge without action is a madness, and action without knowledge is a thing of no value. A knowledge that does not pull you back from sin today, and does not set alight within you the longing to obey your Lord, will not stand between you and the Fire tomorrow. If you do not put your hand to a righteous deed today, and do not begin to repair the years you have spent, then on the Day of Judgment you will cry out with the cry of those who have understood too late:

فَارْجِعْنَا نَعْمَلْ صَالِحًا

"Send us back, our Lord, that we may do righteous deeds!"

And the answer will come to you:

"Heedless one — that is precisely the place you have just come from."

So summon some courage from within yourself. Stir this body of yours and put it onto the road of God. Spend your strength on the deeds that please Him, for you are walking, step by step, toward the grave. Those who went before you into the earth are waiting at every moment, watching the horizon to see when you will appear among them. Beware of arriving among them empty-handed, with no fruit of obedience in your arms. Abu Bakr al-Siddiq, may God be pleased with him, said:

هَذِهِ الْأَجْسَادُ أَقْفَاصُ الطُّيُورِ أَوْ إِسْطَبَلَاتُ الدَّوَابِّ

"These bodies of ours are either the cages of birds or the stables of beasts."

So consider, soberly, which of the two your body is. If you are among the birds, then when the call comes —

ارْجِعِي إِلَىٰ رَبِّكَ

"Return to your Lord!" —

the cage door will open, and you will fly straight upward into the highest reaches. It was of such a soul that the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said:

اهْتَزَّ عَرْشُ الرَّحْمَنِ لِمَوْتِ سَعْدِ بْنِ مُعَاذٍ

"The Throne of the Most Merciful trembled at the death of Sa'd ibn Mu'adh."

But God forbid that you should be among the beasts — those of whom the verse has been spoken:

أُولَئِكَ كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

"They are like cattle — nay, they are further astray than that."

For if so, then know with certainty that you will be dragged, weighed down with your burdens, from the place of the zawiya, where you sat in the posture of a worshipper, straight into the hawiya, the deep pit of the Fire — from this world directly into the burning.

Shaykh Hasan al-Basri, may God envelop him in mercy, was once handed a cold, sweet drink. The moment his fingers closed around the cup he sighed from the depth of his chest and fell senseless to the ground. When he came back to himself, the people around him asked what had overtaken him. He answered:

ذَكَرْتُ أُمْنِيَّةَ أَهْلِ النَّارِ حِينَ يَقُولُونَ لِأَهْلِ الْجَنَّةِ أَنْ أَفِضُوا عَلَيْنَا مِنَ الْمَاءِ

"I remembered the cry of the people of the Fire, when they will plead with the people of the Garden to pour upon them even a little water."

A cold drink in his hand became, in an instant, the memory of a thirst no creature should ever know.

My beloved, if knowledge alone had been enough for you, if deeds were a thing the soul could quietly do without, then why would God Himself, in the last hours before dawn, call out night after night:

هَلْ مِنْ تَائِبٍ، هَلْ مِنْ سَائِلٍ، هَلْ مِنْ مُسْتَغْفِرٍ

"Is there any who repents? Is there any who asks of Me? Is there any who seeks My forgiveness?"

If mere knowledge had been sufficient, this call from the Most High would be a call into emptiness. But the call is real, and it is going out to a particular kind of servant — the kind of whom He says:

كَانُوا قَلِيلًا مِنَ اللَّيْلِ مَا يَهْجَعُونَ

"They used to sleep but little of the night" — those few servants of God who give up sleep in that last sweet portion of the night, the hour of nearness.

Once a group of the Companions was praising Abdullah ibn Umar, may God be pleased with them both, in the presence of the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him. The Prophet listened and then said:

نِعَمَ الرَّجُلُ هُوَ لَوْ كَانَ يُصَلِّي بِاللَّيْلِ

"He is a fine man — if only he would pray at night," meaning those voluntary prayers in the final hours before the dawn, the prayers without which there is no real progress on the road to God.

And on another occasion he said to one of his Companions:

لَا تُكْثِرِ النَّوْمَ بِاللَّيْلِ، فَإِنَّ كَثْرَةَ النَّوْمِ بِاللَّيْلِ تَدْعُ صَاحِبَهَا فَقِيرًا يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ

"Do not sleep too much at night, for too much sleep at night leaves the one who keeps it a pauper on the Day of Resurrection" — having let the season of closeness pass him by, having missed the remembrance and the prayer and the devotion of those final, blessed hours.

And God Himself addressed His Prophet directly, peace and blessings be upon him:

وَمِنَ اللَّيْلِ فَتَهَجَّدْ بِهِ نَافِلَةً لَّكَ

"And in part of the night, rise from sleep and pray it as an addition for you" — Tahajjud, the night vigil, and a benefit beyond measure to your soul.

This is no suggestion. This is a command from the Lord of the worlds to His own beloved.

And of those who answer, He says with the tone of a Lord whose heart is moved by His servants:

وَبِالْأَسْحَارِ هُمْ يَسْتَغْفِرُونَ

"And in the hours before dawn, they would seek forgiveness."

This is gratitude from God toward such servants. And in another place:

وَالْمُسْتَغْفِرِينَ بِالْأَسْحَارِ

"And those who seek forgiveness in the hours before dawn."

This is honor from God for such servants — that He should mention them by their hour.

The Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him, master of this world and the next, said that there are three sounds in which the Most High takes a particular delight: the crowing of the rooster, because the rooster rouses the sleepers to the night prayer; the recitation of the Holy Qur'an; and the voices of those who in the last portion of the night beg their Lord to forgive them and turn back to Him in repentance.

Shaykh Sufyan al-Thawri, may God envelop him in mercy, one of the close friends of God, said:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ تَعَالَى خَلَقَ رِيحًا تَهْبُ وَفَتَ الْأَسْحَارِ، تَحْمِلُ الْأَذْكَارَ وَالِاسْتِغْفَارَ إِلَى
الْمَلِكِ الْجَبَّارِ

"God the Exalted has created a wind that blows in the last part of the night. At that hour, the voices of those servants who are remembering Him and asking His forgiveness are gathered up by this wind and carried into the Court of the Sovereign, the Compeller."

And Sufyan, may God be merciful to him, also said this. When the night first begins, an angel beneath the Throne of God calls out for the worshippers to rise — and those whom God has favored with tawfiq, with the gift of being enabled to obey, rise and pray. In the middle of the night a second angel calls out for the obedient and devoted servants to rise — and they rise and stand in prayer through to the time of sahr, the last sweet portion. When sahr arrives, a third angel calls out for those who seek forgiveness to rise — and they rise, and the air of the room is filled with whispered pleas for pardon. Then, just before the breaking of the day, a fourth angel cries out, and his cry is not gentle: "Heedless ones — get up! The day has broken upon you!" And those who hear him only at the last rise from their beds in the manner of the dead rising from the graves on the Day of Resurrection — startled, late, with the night already spent.

My beloved son, it is recorded in the last counsels of Luqman, peace be upon him, that he turned to his own son and said:

يَا بُنَيَّ، لَا يَكُونَنَّ الدِّيكُ أَكْيَسَ مِنْكَ، فَإِنَّهُ يُنَادِي بِالْأَسْحَارِ وَأَنْتَ نَائِمٌ

"My son — do not let the rooster turn out to be more sensible than you. He stands up in the last hours of the night and announces the time of remembrance and glorifies his Lord, while you lie buried in the deep sleep of forgetfulness and carelessness and neglect."

And the same truth has been put into verse by one who saw himself clearly:

لَقَدْ هَتَفْتُ فِي جُنْحِ لَيْلٍ حَمَامَةٌ عَلَى فَنٍّ وَهَذَا وَإِنِّي لَنَائِمٌ

كَذَبْتُ وَبَيَّتَ اللَّهُ لَوْ كُنْتُ عَاشِقًا لَمَا سَبَقْتَنِي بِالْبُكَاءِ الْحَمَائِمُ

وَأَزُغُمُ أَنِّي هَائِمٌ ذُو صَبَابَةٍ لَهُ بِي وَلَا أَبْكِي وَتَبْكِي الْبَهَائِمُ

In the deep of the night a dove on her branch called out to her Lord, while I lay there, asleep.

By the House of God, I am a liar. Had I been a true lover, the doves would not have outstripped me in weeping for the One I have been parted from.

Yet here I am, claiming to be a wanderer wasted by longing for Him — and my eyes stay dry, while even the dumb beasts are weeping for their Maker.

Read those lines, my son, and then look honestly at your own pillow. Tonight, when the wind of the last hours blows, let it find something of yours to carry — a word of remembrance, a plea for pardon, a breath turned toward Him — so that the rooster does not, in the end, prove the wiser of the two of you, and the doves do not have to keep the vigil alone.

4. Worship Is Obedience, Nothing Less

My dear son, after a night like that, you may wake wondering what, exactly, all this striving is *for*. So let me speak plainly about a thing people pretend to understand but rarely do: what worship actually is, and what obedience actually is. They are one word with two faces. Worship is obedience. Obedience is worship. There is no third thing hiding between them.

Hear me carefully. Obedience and worship mean one thing: that you live in accordance with the *Shari'ah* of the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him — his Law, his road, his pattern. Whatever the commandments ask of you — that you do a thing, or that you refrain from a thing; whether the guidance comes from his words or from the silent eloquence of his example — your life must conform to it.

Whatever you do, whatever you leave undone, whatever you speak, whatever you keep behind your teeth: all of it lined up with him. If you speak, speak as he taught. If you fall silent, let your silence be the silence he kept. If you act, act in his manner. If you abstain, abstain as he abstained.

Now hear the sharp edge of this, because most people sleep through it. If you do some act believing it to be worship, and yet you do not do it under the command of the Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him — then it is not worship at all. It is a sin wearing the costume of prayer, a transgression dressed as a fast. Don't you know that the man who fasts on the day of Eid, or on the days of Hajj, has sinned in his fasting? The shape of the act is fasting — the empty stomach, the dry mouth, the restraint from food and drink — but because it stands outside the Prophet's command, peace and blessings be upon him, the one who performs it is a wrongdoer. The form is worship; the reality is rebellion.

So too with prayer. If a man prays after `Asr until the sun has set, or after Fajr before the sun has climbed to its permitted height — or if he stands to pray on ground he has wrongfully seized — he is called *athim*, a sinner, and *fasiq*, a transgressor. His back bends in *ruku*, his forehead touches the earth in *sujud*, his lips shape the recitation — and still it is not correct, because it was not done as the Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him, drew the line.

And turn the matter over and look at the other side. A husband and wife come together in the lawful intimacy of their marriage bed. To the ignorant gaze, what they do may look like the very stuff of appetite, the very thing the pious are supposed to flee. But because it sits inside the guidance of the Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him, it is *halal*, and it is no sin at all — and it may even be, depending on the intention, a path to reward.

So it is established, settled, and beyond clever objection: worship is another name for obedience. Worship is obedience. Take that sentence with you.

In the same way, prayer and fasting count as worship only when they are performed along the lines the Divine guidance has drawn. Therefore, my dear son, let everything you say and everything you do conform to the commands of the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him. Every action you perform, every conversation you enter, every transaction you make — measure them against the *Shari'ah*. Because any knowledge, any practice of God's creation that falls outside the *Shari'ah* is, plain and simple, misguidance. It does not lead human beings toward the truth; it leads them away from it. This is precisely why the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him, was sent to abrogate every religious dispensation that came before him. He is the final pattern. There is no road around him.

So do nothing without his guidance — nothing at all — and be utterly certain of this: you cannot advance one step on the Path of God, Exalted is He, by the mere accumulation of knowledge. You cannot read your way to Him. You cannot collect your way to Him. This Path is walked through earnest effort and *mujahadah* — that inner war, that disciplined exercise of the soul, that ceaseless friction against the lower self. The pleasures of the *nafs* and its endless demands must be cut through with the sword of *mujahadah*. They will not yield to anything softer.

And hear me on this, because in every age there are men who try to slip past it. These desires of the lower self cannot be uprooted through licentiousness dressed up as freedom, nor through the deceptions of false Sufis — men who claim the station of Sufism, who have learned its vocabulary, who wear its patched cloak and use its phrases like passwords, while inside they are hollow, devious, and untouched. The true Sufis are something else entirely. They are those who have come into an intimate relationship with God by way of souls genuinely purified, who have rooted out evil from the deepest folds of their being through *mujahadah* that was real and not a performance. Know the difference. Your soul depends on knowing the difference.

God, Exalted is He, is not charmed by the subtleties of philosophy spun out by a tongue whose owner lives drowning in sin. A tongue that says beautiful things while the heart squats in heedlessness, enslaved to its appetites — this is one of the gravest misfortunes that can befall a human being. Eloquence with a dead heart is not a gift. It is a warning.

Unless you sever the desires and inclinations of your lower self with the sword of truth and *mujahadah*, the light of *ma'rifah* — that deep, intimate, conscious knowledge of God, that direct awareness, that lived relationship with Him — will not dawn within your heart. It will not. No

matter how many books are on your shelf. No matter how many teachers have signed your *ijazah*.

My dear son, you have asked me about several spiritual matters, and some of them are of a kind that cannot fully be set down in writing or speech. When you reach that high station of spiritual unveiling, you will come to know them yourself — directly, without intermediary. The lesson of love is not taught from outside. It is born inside you and learned from within. If you arrive there, knowing these things will be like passing from one spiritual station into the next — *mustahilat*, things that cannot be transferred by description, only entered. For *'ishq* — that intense, burning love — is itself another name for love and for the fervent thirst to seek the Beloved, what we call *dhawq*, the taste. Love and *dhawq* cannot be conveyed by speech or by writing. Their essence cannot be handed over. Just as no one who tries can really describe to you the taste of sweetness, or sourness, or bitterness — words circle the thing and never land on it — so it is here. Know, then, that if you reach that destination, you will come to know all this by yourself. And if you cannot reach it, then truth can at least be sketched, in writing and speech, to some partial degree.

My dear son, some of what you asked is of a kind that can in fact be addressed in writing and speech, and most of that I have already answered, at length, in my book *Ihya 'Ulum al-Din* — the Revival of the Knowledge of the Path to God — and in other books, in detail. You may read them there. But I will also explain those matters here, in a concise form, *insha'Allah*.

Now, the second thing you asked: what is essential for those who walk on the Path of God, Exalted is He — the sincere seekers of Him. Let me lay it out for you, plainly.

The first condition is that you must hold the conviction of the fear of God to such a depth that you do not slip into *bid`ah* — innovation in the religion — meaning any matter that runs against the established principles of the Qur'an and the Sunnah. And by the Sunnah I mean the whole of what the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him, brought us: his teachings, his actions, his outward conduct, and his inward states — his contentment, his patience, his gratitude, his certitude in God, his intimacy with Him, his *ma`rifah*, his deep recognition of Him, his intense love for Him, and the rest.

The second condition is that you make a true and complete repentance — *tawbah nasuh* — in such a way that you do not crawl back to the humiliation of sin. Not a polite repentance. Not a seasonal repentance. A repentance that closes the door behind you.

The third condition is that you keep even your enemies satisfied, so far as it is in your power — to the extent that no one among God's creation has any unfulfilled claim hanging over you. No wronged person waiting for you on the Day. No debt of speech or coin or honour left lying.

The fourth condition is that you acquire enough knowledge of the *Shari`ah* to follow and obey the commandments that are obligatory upon you, personally. It is not an obligation upon you to learn more of the *Shari`ah* than that. From the other branches of knowledge, learn only what is obligatory. No more. The seeking and hoarding of knowledge beyond what your own obligation demands is *fard kifayah* — a communal obligation, discharged when enough of the Muslim community attends to it; but if no one attends to it, the whole community carries the sin of that neglect. Your share, then, is what your own neck requires.

You should know what has been narrated about the intimate friends of God, His saints. Shibli, may God shower His mercy upon him, said:

خَدَمْتُ أَرْبَعَ مِائَةِ شَيْخٍ وَقَرَأْتُ أَرْبَعَةَ آلَافِ حَدِيثٍ، ثُمَّ اخْتَرْتُ مِنْهَا حَدِيثًا
وَاحِدًا فَعَمِلْتُ بِهِ وَخَلَّيْتُ مَا سِوَاهُ، فَإِنِّي تَأَمَّلْتُهُ فَوَجَدْتُ فِيهِ نَجَاتِي وَخَلَاصِي،
وَوَجَدْتُ فِيهِ عِلْمَ الْأَوَّلِينَ وَالْآخِرِينَ، فَاكْتَفَيْتُ بِهِ.

"I served four hundred spiritual masters, and I read four thousand sayings of the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him. Then I chose, out of them all, a single hadith. I acted upon that one and set the rest aside — for when I pondered it, I found within it my salvation and my deliverance, and I found within it the knowledge of the first generations and the last. So it was enough for me."

And the hadith was this:

إِعْمَلْ لِدُنْيَاكَ بِقَدْرِ مُقَامِكَ فِيهَا، وَاعْمَلْ لِآخِرَتِكَ بِقَدْرِ بَقَائِكَ فِيهَا، وَاعْمَلْ لِلَّهِ
بِقَدْرِ حَاجَتِكَ إِلَيْهِ، وَاعْمَلْ لِلنَّارِ بِقَدْرِ صَبْرِكَ عَلَيْهَا.

"Work for this world in proportion to how long you will stay in it. Work for the next world in proportion to how long you will remain there. Work for God in proportion to your need of Him. And work toward the Fire in proportion to how much of its pain you can bear."

My dear son, look at what is laid bare in that hadith and you will see that you do not need a great heaping mountain of knowledge. Because, as I told you, the pursuit and acquisition of knowledge beyond your personal obligation is *fard kifayah* — a duty discharged on behalf of the community when enough of its people undertake it; but if no one undertakes it, then

the whole community bears the sin of that neglect. So the question for *you* is not how much can be learned, but how much you must learn to obey. Beyond that, what your soul needs is not more pages — it is *`amal*, action upon what is already in your hand.

Pay close attention, then, to the tradition that follows, so that your certitude may rise to a station where doubt no longer finds a perch.

5. Eight Lessons from Thirty-Three Years

Listen, then, to a tradition that has stayed with me for years, and let it lodge in your heart as it has lodged in mine. It concerns a student and his teacher, and though it is short in its telling, it contains an entire curriculum of the soul.

Among the disciples of Shaykh Shafiq al-Balkhi, upon whom be the mercy of God, was a young man named Hatim ibn Isam, who later himself became a master of the inward path through the long, patient training of that same Shaykh. You should understand what a disciple is among such people: he is one who seeks elevation and enlightenment through the purification of the soul from every base desire and tendency, and who undertakes that purification under the guidance of a master who has himself already arrived at that station through the training, the nearness, and the discipline of yet another guide before him. This is a chain, my son — a chain of living transmission, not of books.

One day Shaykh Shafiq turned to Hatim and asked him, "Hatim, how long have you been in my company — how long have you been close to me, listening to what I teach?"

Hatim answered, "Thirty-three years."

The Shaykh said, "And in all that time, what benefit have you taken from me?"

Hatim replied, "I have taken eight benefits from you."

When the Shaykh heard this, he said softly:

إِنَّا لِلَّهِ وَإِنَّا إِلَيْهِ رَاجِعُونَ

"To God we belong, and to Him is our return."

— the verse the believer recites in the hour of loss and grief. Then he said, "Hatim, I have spent my whole life in teaching and training, and you have taken only eight benefits from me?"

Hatim answered him, "My teacher, if you ask me for the truth, then the truth is exactly what I have said. I need nothing more. These eight benefits of knowledge are entirely sufficient for me, for I am certain that through them I shall attain salvation and success in this life and in the life to come."

The Shaykh said, "Very well. Tell me, then — what are these eight?"

And Hatim began.

"My teacher, the first benefit is this. I looked at the people of this world and I saw that every one of them has a beloved. But these beloveds are of a particular kind: some accompany their lover only until the illness that brings death; some go with him as far as the moment of death itself; and some walk with him only as far as the lip of the grave. After the burial, all of them turn around and return. Not one of them descends into the grave to dwell with the dead, to keep him company in that darkness, to share with him that solitude, that narrowness, that terror. I sat with this

for a long time, and I said to myself: the only true beloved is the one who goes down into the grave with you — who dwells with you there, who offers you his company, who lights the grave like a candle, who walks with you as a partner on the Day of Judgement and through every station you must cross after burial until that Day. And when I looked for such a beloved, I found that he is only one: a person's own righteous deeds. So I made my righteous deeds my beloved, so that they would go down with me into my grave when I die, so that they would keep me company there, so that they would burn for me as a lit candle within that earth, so that they would be my partner through every stage of the world to come, and so that they would never, ever leave my side."

Shaykh Shafiq said, "Bravo, Hatim. You have spoken excellently. Now the second."

"My teacher, the second benefit is this. I looked again at the people of the world and I saw that every one of them was running after the pleasures and the desires of the *nafs* — that lower self which incites a man to evil — and that every one of them was utterly subservient to whatever it demanded. And as I watched this, I called to mind the noble verse of the Qur'an:

وَأَمَّا مَنْ خَافَ مَقَامَ رَبِّهِ وَنَهَى النَّفْسَ عَنِ الْهَوَىٰ ۖ ﴿٤٠﴾ فَإِنَّ الْجَنَّةَ هِيَ الْمَأْوَىٰ

"But as for the one who has stood in awe of his Lord's presence and restrained his self from base desire — surely Paradise is the place of rest." (Qur'an 79:40–41)

And in that moment certitude descended on me: the Wise Qur'an is correct, and the Book of God is truth. So I took my stand against my *nafs*. I resolved to oppose it. I disciplined it so completely, refusing it any

desire it asked for, that at last it gave up its rebellion and began to find its peace and its satisfaction in the worship of God, the Exalted."

The Shaykh said, "May God, the Exalted, place His blessing in your good deeds. Now the third."

"My teacher, the third benefit is this. When I looked at the people, I saw that every one of them was busy — through great pain and hard labour — accumulating the possessions of this perishing world: money, property, goods. And the more they amassed, the more pleased they became with themselves. But I contemplated this generous verse:

مَا عِنْدَكُمْ يَنْفَدُ وَمَا عِنْدَ اللَّهِ بَاقٍ

"All that is with you is bound to come to an end, but all that is with God endures forever." (Qur'an 16:96)

So whatever I had accumulated of the things of this world, I spent it all in the way of God by distributing it among the pious poor and the needy — so that those possessions would be set down as a deposit with God, the Exalted, held in trust for me, and so that they would become an immense good and a ransom — that is, a deliverance — for me in the life to come."

The Shaykh said, "Hatim, may God reward you for what you have spent in His way. You have spoken well and you have acted well. Now the fourth."

"My teacher, the fourth benefit is this. I looked at the people of the world and I saw that they differ wildly in where they locate honour and greatness. Some believe that grandeur belongs to the nation or tribe that is large and powerful, and so they take pride in their tribe. Some believe

it belongs to the man of abundant wealth, possessions, family, and dependents, and so they boast of their riches and their children. Some believe it is found in the display of rage — in striking, killing, slaughter, and plunder — and they boast of that. And some believe it lies in extravagant spending, and they hold up such waste as a source of distinction and pride. But I reflected on the verse in which God, the Exalted, says:

إِنَّ أَكْرَمَكُمْ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ أَتْقَاكُمْ

"Truly, the most noble of you in the sight of God is the most God-conscious among you." (Qur'an 49:13)

This alone is correct. This alone is the truth. Everything else that the people of the world believe is a hollow conjecture and nothing more. So I adopted *taqwa* — that reverent consciousness, awe, and fear of God — that I might be counted among those of the highest rank in His sight."

The Shaykh said, "Hatim, may God be pleased with you. You have spoken excellently. Now the fifth."

"My teacher, the fifth benefit is this. I looked at the people and I saw them locked in complaint against one another. And when I traced the cause of these complaints, I found that the root was envy, jealousy, and enmity — and that all of those, in turn, sprang from competition: competition over greatness, over rank, over possessions, over wealth, even over knowledge. Then I contemplated this verse from the Holy Qur'an:

نَحْنُ قَسَمْنَا بَيْنَهُمْ مَعِيشَتَهُمْ فِي الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا

"It is We who have distributed their means of livelihood among them in the life of this world." (Qur'an 43:32)

And I reflected: God, the Blessed and Exalted, has already apportioned every possession and every rank from the very beginning of creation — and no creature has any voice or control in the matter. So I ceased to compete with anyone. I ceased to harbour jealousy toward anyone. I rested content with God's distribution of the bounties of this world and with what He has appointed for me, and I made my peace with the whole of creation by laying down every envy and every enmity I had ever held against any creature of God."

The Shaykh said, "Hatim, you have spoken the truth and you are doing what is right. Now the sixth."

"My teacher, the sixth benefit is this. When I looked at the people, I saw that every one of them carried enmity in his heart toward someone else for one reason or another. Then I reflected on this verse:

إِنَّ الشَّيْطَانَ لَكُمْ عَدُوٌّ فَاتَّخِذُوهُ عَدُوًّا

"Truly, Satan is your enemy — so treat him as your enemy." (Qur'an 35:6)

And certitude entered me: God's words are the truth, and I am to hold no enmity toward any human being. From that day forward, I took Satan alone as my enemy. I refused to obey any prompting of his. Instead I cultivated obedience to God, I followed His commandments, and I gave myself entirely to His worship and His service. This is the right way —

the *sirat al-mustaqim*, the straight road in which there is no crookedness — just as God Himself, the Exalted, has declared:

أَلَمْ أَعْهَدْ إِلَيْكُمْ يَا بَنِي آدَمَ أَنْ لَا تَعْبُدُوا الشَّيْطَانَ إِنَّهُ لَكُمْ عَدُوٌّ مُبِينٌ ۖ وَأَنْ
اعْبُدُونِي ۚ هَذَا صِرَاطٌ مُسْتَقِيمٌ

"Did I not make this covenant with you, O Children of Adam — that you should not worship Satan, for he is your open and avowed enemy — and that you should worship Me alone? This is the straight road." (Qur'an 36:60–61)"

The Shaykh said, "Hatim, you have done well and you have spoken well. Now the seventh."

"My teacher, the seventh benefit is this. I looked at the people and I saw every one of them consumed by his livelihood and the search for his daily bread, pouring all his strength into that pursuit. And in the race, many of them no longer trouble themselves to distinguish between what is *halal* — permitted — and what is *haram* — forbidden; they debase themselves by seeking out earnings that are doubtful or outright unlawful. Then I reflected on this verse:

وَمَا مِنْ دَابَّةٍ فِي الْأَرْضِ إِلَّا عَلَى اللَّهِ رِزْقُهَا

"There is no creature that walks the earth whose sustenance is not the responsibility of God." (Qur'an 11:6)

And certitude descended on me: the Wise Qur'an is true and correct — and I, too, am one of those creatures of God walking upon the earth. So I gave myself to the worship of God and held firm to the certainty that He

would bring my sustenance to me, since He Himself has promised to provide it."

The Shaykh said, "You have done well and you have spoken well. Now the eighth."

"My teacher, the eighth benefit is this. When I looked at the people, I found that every one of them rests his reliance and his trust on something or someone — some place their trust in their possessions, some lean on other people. Then I pondered this holy verse in which God, the Blessed and Exalted, says:

وَمَنْ يَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى اللَّهِ فَهُوَ حَسْبُهُ

"And whoever places his trust in God — He is enough for him."
(Qur'an 65:3)

And I remembered too the words:

وَهُوَ حَسْبِي وَنِعْمَ الْوَكِيلُ

"He is enough for me, and what an excellent Guardian He is."

So I adopted complete reliance upon God in every matter, large and small."

When Shaykh Shafiq al-Balkhi, upon whom be the mercy of God, had heard these eight, he said: "Hatim — may God grant you His *tawfiq*, that is, may He enable you to perform righteous deeds and to walk firmly upon His path. You have spoken most excellent things. I have seen in the Torah, in the Gospel of Jesus, in the Psalms of David, and in that praiseworthy criterion between right and wrong — the Holy Qur'an —

that all four of these Books of God speak of these very same eight benefits. Whoever acts upon these eight principles is as one who has acted upon all four of God's Books."

Now hold this story still in your mind for a moment, my son, and look at it honestly. A man sat at the feet of his master for thirty-three years and walked away with eight sentences. But those eight sentences had become his life — they had passed from his ear into his heart, and from his heart into his limbs. This is what knowledge looks like when it has been lived. A thousand pages read and unobserved are lighter on the Day of Judgement than one verse made flesh in a single action. So choose, from these eight, the one that strikes nearest your own condition — and begin there, today, before the night closes around you.

6. Finding a True Guide

You now know, from the traditions I have placed before you, that you do not need a great quantity of knowledge. A few sayings, lived, will carry you further than libraries skimmed. So let me return to where I was leading you, and describe the inward conditions required of anyone who sets out, in earnest, on the Path of God.

The fifth condition, binding upon every seeker of the Path of Allah the Exalted, is that you must have a *Shaykh al-Kamil* — a perfected spiritual guide — who walks ahead of you, reaches into the soil of your soul, pulls out what is choking it, and plants in its place what is noble. Think of a farmer with his crop. When he sees weeds rising among the grain he does not leave them to flourish; he stoops, takes them out by the root, throws them aside, and then waters what remains so that it grows clean and strong. The training of a soul is no different. At every stage of the journey, the traveler on the Path of Allah has no other remedy, no other

cure, no other way through — except by the hand of a *Murshid al-Kamil*, a true and perfected guide. For Allah the Exalted sent Prophet Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him, to His servants precisely so that he might be an illuminated guide upon the Way of Allah and lead people onto it. And when the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, departed this world, he left behind his deputies and successors in his place, so that they would stand as living proofs of the Way of Allah the Exalted, until the Day of Judgement.

So you must have a perfected guide — a *Shaykh al-Kamil* — who, for the sake of this very walking, stands as an illuminated proof and deputy of Prophet Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him.

Now hear me carefully on *what* such a guide must be, for here many are deceived, and the deceit costs souls.

The one who is heir to the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, and whom you take as your Shaykh, must be a scholar — but understand at once that not every scholar is a *Shaykh al-Kamil*. The work itself — guiding people inwardly, purifying their souls, drawing them forward on the Way of Allah — can only be carried by a person who possesses certain definite qualities. I will name some of these qualities briefly, so that no foolish or misguided man may put on the cloak and claim what is not his. Such impostors are many, my son. Their purpose is to harvest people for worldly gain, and the damage they do to this most delicate dimension of Islam is immense; many souls have been led astray by their hands.

Hear, then, who alone is fit to be a Shaykh. He is one who has turned his face away from love of the world, love of honor, and love of worldly rank, and who has taken *Bay'a* — a solemn covenant with Allah, sworn upon the hand of his Shaykh, pledging to turn away from evil inwardly and

outwardly, to excel on the Path of God by obeying His commandments, by keeping clear of His prohibitions, and by striving to purify his soul in pursuit of God's nearness and approval — with a perfected guide, who in turn has taken *Bay'a* with his own perfected guide, and so on, link by link, until the chain reaches back unbroken to the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him. Such a man must himself have passed through every kind of *Riyada* and *Mujahada* — the spiritual exertions and disciplines that scour the soul — and must have obeyed every commandment of the Prophet Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him. He must eat little. He must sleep little. He must pray abundantly — the five obligatory prayers and the supererogatory prayers besides. He must fast often. He must give generously, in charity and in the Way of God. Within him, both in what is hidden and in what is visible, every praiseworthy character should have taken up residence: patience, gratitude, certitude in Allah, generosity, contentment, trustworthiness, tolerance, seriousness of purpose, humility, obedience to Allah, truthfulness, modesty and reserve, dignity, tranquility, and every virtue of that family. He should have received a light from among the lights of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, so that every evil quality — miserliness, jealousy, enmity, worldly expectation, anger, rebellion — has been burned out of him. And he must rely on no source of knowledge except what we have received from the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him.

These qualities, my son — the marks by which perfected guides are known — are what make a man fit to be a deputy and heir of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him. To follow such a one is the correct way.

I will tell you the truth: such guides are exceedingly hard to find. But if you have been granted this wealth, this blessing — that you have found

such a guide, and that he has accepted you among his disciples, his *Murids* — then it becomes binding upon you to maintain, in everything outward and everything inward, respect, honor, and proper etiquette toward him.

Hear first the outward etiquettes. Do not argue with your guide. If a dispute begins to rise in you, and you think he has overlooked something, do not raise an objection. Do not station yourself at the place of prayer at all hours; rather, when the time of prayer comes, go to the place, pray, roll up your mat, and leave. Do not perform long supererogatory prayers in front of the Shaykh after each obligatory one. Whatever the perfected guide commands you, obey to the best of your strength. And know this — fix it firmly in your understanding — a true spiritual guide cannot and will not command a disciple to do anything that the *Shari'a*, the law of Allah, has forbidden. It is only the false impostor, the one who lacks the qualities I have described, who will command his disciples to what is *haram*.

Hear now the inward etiquettes. Whatever you hear outwardly from your *Murshid*, do not entertain even the faintest doubt in your heart about his words or his deeds — for if you do, you will be counted among the hypocrites. And if you find that you cannot sustain this inward sincerity, then withdraw from his company until the inside of you comes back into agreement with the outside of you. Better an honest distance than a deceitful nearness.

The sixth condition is that you, the seeker of truth, guard yourself against the deceptions of the *Nafs* — the lower self. It is an inward presence, subtle, hidden from the outward eye, yet plainly seen by one who has been given inner sight. It whispers into the heart and commands you to evil. You can only do this — guard against it — if you abandon the gatherings of those who are ill in character and those who

are ignorant. Cut yourself loose from their company. Only then will Shaytan's grip on your heart weaken, and every satanic influence be torn out by the root. And know that this satanic company may come to you from among human beings or from among the *Jinn* — that invisible creation of God formed from fire, the kind from which Shaytan himself comes and from which he gathers his followers.

The seventh condition is that, in every condition and at every turn, you prefer humility and freedom from greed over wealth, and that you wrap yourself in contentment, accepting the will of Allah as it comes.

These seven conditions, my son, are essential — for every traveler on the Path of Allah the Exalted, and for every seeker of truth.

7. Sufism, Servitude, Trust, Sincerity

You have asked me, my son, what Tasawwuf truly is — and I will tell you plainly, for the word has been used and misused until its meaning is almost lost. Tasawwuf rests on two qualities, and a person who lacks either of them has no right to the name, no matter what robe he wears or what circle he sits in. The first quality is that the servant be obedient to Allah — and by this I mean acting in accordance with the Shari'ah, the outward law of Islam, in all that it commands, all that it obliges, and all that it forbids. The second is that the seeker be compassionate toward every creature Allah has made, a doer of good to all of them — and this is impossible until you have first purified your soul of every evil quality clinging to it, and then adorned it with every noble one in their place. The one who perseveres in living the Shari'ah, and who sincerely desires the betterment and the true success of every human being, is rightly called a Sufi. That is the correct application of the word — and I say this against the distorted usages that have spread in our time, where the

name is claimed by those who have abandoned both halves of what it means.

Loyalty and obedience to Allah, understand well, mean that the seeker sacrifices his own happiness for the sake of his Lord. Sincerity toward people means that the seeker does not keep relationships alive for personal motives, but is selfless in them, performing selfless service, untouched by self-interest. He dedicates himself instead to the welfare of all people — with the condition, always, that this welfare must remain inside the boundaries of the Shari'ah, the Divine law. There is no welfare worth giving outside of it.

You have asked me, next, what servitude is. Servitude consists of three things, and I will name them in order. The first is obedience to the commandments of the Shari'ah. The second is contentment with the decree and destiny that Allah, the Exalted, has appointed for you. The third — and this is the hardest of the three — is the abandonment of your own desires and your own claims, and the acceptance of, and indeed the happiness with, the Will and Power of Allah, the Exalted. A servant who walks on those three legs is a servant in truth.

You have also asked me what reliance on God is — what Tawakkul means. Know this: Tawakkul is to hold a firm belief, a settled certitude, in what Allah, the Exalted, has promised. To say it more plainly: you believe, with conviction so deep that nothing can disturb it, that whatever Allah has decreed for you, you will surely receive — and if every soul in the entire world were to conspire together to keep it from you, they could not keep it from you. And what He has not written in your destiny — no effort of yours, and no combined effort of the whole world together, will ever bring it to your hand. Live inside that certainty, and the trembling of the heart over provision and outcome will leave you.

You have also asked me what sincerity to God is — what Ikhlas means. Know this: Ikhlas means that all your deeds are exclusively for the sake of Allah and for His pleasure. Whatever you do must not be for display, not for the eyes of others — not Riya. When you perform a good deed, your heart must not tilt, even slightly, toward impressing people or earning their praise. Your heart should not be gladdened by their admiration, nor grieved by their criticism. And understand the root of this disease: Riya is born from the praises and honors of people. So the cure for Riya is to see the whole universe as wholly subject to the Power and Control of Allah, the Exalted — and to regard every created thing as equivalent to pebbles and stones, knowing that stones possess no power to bring you grief and no power to bring you comfort. If you can truly look upon all creation in that light, you will be freed from Riya. But so long as you believe that mortal, created beings have the power to cause you pain or to gift you ease, Riya will not leave your heart. It cannot.

My dear beloved son — your remaining questions, the ones I have not addressed here, fall into two kinds. Some of them I have already answered in books I have written, and you may consult those books at your leisure. Others are of such a nature that writing their answers down is not permissible — they belong to a different mode of transmission. So take what is written here, and put it steadily into practice. Through the practice itself, those matters which you do not yet understand will become clear to you, one by one, in their own time.

My dear beloved son — after this, whatever question you find difficult, whatever matter you cannot comprehend, do not seek its answer except through the tongue of your own heart. Allah has said:

وَلَوْ أَنَّهُمْ صَبَرُوا حَتَّى تَخْرُجَ إِلَيْهِمْ لَكَانَ خَيْرًا لَهُمْ

"Had they been patient until you came out to them, it would have been better for them." (Qur'an 49:5)

Had those people exercised patience — instead of clamoring outside the house of the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him — until he himself came out to them, it would have been better for them. Learn the lesson in that verse, and apply it to your own questions. Do not pound on the door. Wait, and what is meant for you will come out to meet you.

Accept, too, the counsel of Khidr, peace be upon him, when he spoke to Moses:

فَلَا تَسْأَلْنِي عَنْ شَيْءٍ حَتَّى أُحْدِثَ لَكَ مِنْهُ ذِكْرًا

"Then do not ask me about anything until I myself mention it to you." (Qur'an 18:70)

If you wish to walk with the guide, do not press him with questions before their season. When the moment is ripe, he himself will raise the matter and explain it. Do not be hasty. When the time comes, you will be told and you will be shown.

سَأُرِيكُمْ آيَاتِي فَلَا تَسْتَعْجِلُونِ

"I will show you My signs, so do not ask Me to hasten them."

That is Allah, the Exalted, speaking — I will soon show you My signs, so do not seek to hurry the matter. Do not ask before the right time arrives.

When you reach that spiritually elevated stage, you will see it for yourself. Hold to this certainty, then: unless you set out toward the destination, you will neither arrive at it nor be able to see what awaits there.

أَوَلَمْ يَسِيرُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ فَيَنْظُرُوا

"Have they not traveled the earth, that they might see?"

The seeing is on the road. There is no seeing without the traveling.

My dear beloved son — by Allah! If you illuminate your heart by driving out the darkness of evil that has settled in it, you will behold wondrous things. I do not exaggerate. But strive with your utmost at every step along the way. Without that striving, the purpose will not be achieved. There is no shortcut around the soul's exertion; the road is the road.

Shaykh Dhu al-Nun al-Misri, may Allah shower His mercy upon him, once said something to one of his students that I want you to hear as if he were saying it to you now:

إِنْ قَدَرْتَ عَلَىٰ بَذْلِ الرُّوحِ فَتَّعَالَ، وَإِلَّا فَلَا تَشْتَغِلْ بِنَزَاهَةِ الصُّوفِيَّةِ وَالْقَالَ

"If you can offer up your soul, then come; and if not, do not occupy yourself with the elegant talk of the Sufis."

If you have the courage to exert your utmost with your very soul in this way — to spend it, to pour it out — then come and step onto this path. And if you do not, then do not merely busy yourself with the beautiful sayings of the Sufis, repeating their words while their meaning passes

you by. The sayings are not the path. The spending of the soul is the path. Choose, my son, which of the two you will be.

8. Four to Avoid, Four to Embrace

My dear beloved son — having spoken of the spending of the soul, let me now bring my counsel to a close with eight admonitions. Four of them you must take up, and four you must lay down, so that the knowledge you have gathered does not one day rise against you on the Day when nothing rises with us except what we truly were. I will begin with the four you must lay down.

The first is this: as far as you possibly can, do not enter into religious disputes with anyone, and do not argue — not over matters of faith, not over anything else. There are hidden harms in such quarrels, and on the scale, the harms outweigh whatever small good might come of them. Debate is the wellspring from which a whole landscape of evils flows: ostentation, the inner showmanship called *Riya*; jealousy; arrogance; resentment; enmity; pride; and the swelling of the ego. Now, if a discussion arises between you and another person, and what you truly want is that the truth come to light, then your intention may be sound. But the soundness of that intention has two signs, and they are unsparing. The first sign is that you are equally pleased whether the truth comes out through your own tongue or through the tongue of the one across from you — for what matters to you is the truth, not the mouth it travels through. The second sign is that you would rather have the matter discussed in private than in front of an audience. If, on the other hand, you find yourself in an exchange in which you are certain you are right and the other is arguing only for the sake of arguing, then be on guard at once. Stop. End the conversation there. Otherwise grudges take

root, resentments grow tall, and no good at all is harvested from that field.

Let me explain something here that I want you to grasp deeply. Asking a question about religion or the spiritual life is like a sick man describing his ailment and its causes before a physician of the heart. The scholar's effort to answer is the physician's effort to cure. The ignorant, then, are the patients; scholars are the physicians; and not every physician is qualified for every disease. An incomplete scholar cannot cure these diseases of the heart. Only the Shaykh al-Kamil, the perfected scholar, can — for only he can recognize the root causes of the affliction. And if the disease has so deepened that even those root causes cannot be located, then a more expert physician must be sought, one who can tell which ailments are still curable and which lie beyond the reach of medicine. To pour effort into curing the incurable is nothing but a squandering of the lamp's oil.

Now know this: the ignorant — the patients in our metaphor — fall into four kinds. Only one of these four can be cured. The other three are beyond healing.

The first kind asks his question out of jealousy, raises his objection out of envy. Jealousy is a fatal disease, and it has no remedy. No matter how sound your answer, no matter how patient your explanation, such a person will see you as an enemy, and the fire inside him will only burn higher when you reply. The better course is silence. The poet captured it exactly:

كُلُّ الْعَدَاوَاتِ قَدْ تُرْجَى إِزَالَتُهَا إِلَّا عَدَاوَةٌ مِّنْ عَادَاكَ مِنْ حَسَدٍ

"Every enmity may be hoped to be removed — except the enmity of one who hates you out of jealousy."

The cure, then, is to leave the jealous man to his sickness. As Allah Himself has said:

فَاعْرِضْ عَنْ مَّن تَوَلَّىٰ عَن ذِكْرِنَا وَلَمْ يُرِدْ إِلَّا الْحَيَاةَ الدُّنْيَا

"So turn away from him who turns away from Our remembrance and desires nothing but the life of this world." (*Qur'an, al-Najm* 53:29)

The second kind is sick from foolishness — from a stunted intelligence. This too is incurable. The Prophet Isa, peace be upon him, said that he was able, by God's leave, to raise the dead, but he was unable to cure the fool. The foolish man is the one who has spent only a brief while sniffing around the edges of knowledge, has not even begun to digest the intellectual and the transmitted sciences, and yet stands up to raise objections against scholars who have given their entire lives to those very disciplines. He does not even notice that his objection wounds — himself, those who resemble him, and the scholars he is so eager to correct. He does not notice that the objection benefits him not at all. The depths of insight a true scholar carries are beyond his reach, and beyond the reach of those like him; that he cannot see this is precisely his foolishness. Step away from such a man. Do not engage him.

The third kind cannot sit still long enough to receive the teachings of those who have actually walked the path. Restless, impatient, he leans on

his own thin understanding and interprets every saying through the lens of his own small interest. His mind cannot lay hold of the truth. Do not answer him either, for the Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him, said:

نَحْنُ مَعَاشِرَ الْأَنْبِيَاءِ أُمِرْنَا أَنْ نُكَلِّمَ النَّاسَ عَلَى قَدْرِ عُقُولِهِمْ

"We, the company of prophets, have been commanded to speak to people according to the measure of their understanding."

And then there is the fourth — the one who can be cured. This is the sincere seeker of the straight path, the Sirat al-Mustaqim; obedient, sharp, intelligent, free of anger, free of bondage to the lower self's appetites, free of jealousy, free of the craving for wealth and renown. Whatever he asks, whatever objection he raises, comes not from envy, not from fault-finding, not from a wish to test you — it comes from a real hunger for truth and right guidance. This is the patient who can be healed. To answer him is not merely permissible. It is obligatory, *wajib*, upon you.

The second thing you must lay down is preaching — the giving of sermons. There are great calamities folded inside that pulpit. If you genuinely believe that whatever you preach you have first lived, then remember what Allah, the Real, said to the Prophet Isa, peace be upon him:

يَا ابْنَ مَرْيَمَ عِظْ نَفْسَكَ، فَإِنْ اتَّعَظْتَ فَعِظِ النَّاسَ، وَإِلَّا فَاسْتَخِي مِنِّي

"O son of Mary, admonish your own self first; then, if it accepts the admonition, admonish the people. Otherwise, feel shame before Me."

And if circumstances put you on the pulpit anyway, then guard against two things. The first: keep out of your sermon all colorful narrations, all theatrical gestures, all hinting and secretive language, all flowery ornament, all sweet poetry meant to charm, anything that overruns the bounds of the Shari'ah, and the inventions of those who claim Sufism without living it. Allah, the Exalted, does not love the showy and the pretentious. When a preacher's speech crosses out of substance and into mere display — when his only aim is to dazzle the listeners with eloquent turns of phrase — be certain that his inner life is in ruin and his heart is cut off from the remembrance of God. The purpose of a sermon is not to put your talents on parade. Its purpose is to speak of the punishment of the Hereafter. To name your own shortcomings in the service of Allah and to grieve openly over the hours you have wasted. To describe the difficult stages that lie ahead on the road to come. To speak of how a person might pass through this world with his faith still intact; of the terrifying appearance of the Angel of Death, Malak al-Mawt, at the moment of dying; of the questioning in the grave by Munkar and Nakir, the two angels who arrive after the burial; of the stations of the Day of Resurrection. To speak of the awesome reckoning on the plain of Hashr, where the whole of humankind will be gathered; of the weighing of deeds in the Mizan, the mighty scale Allah has prepared for that day; of the crossing of the Sirat — the bridge strung over Hell on the way to Paradise, finer than a hair, sharper than a sword, over which every human being must pass; and of all the other terrors of that Day. Set these

realities in front of the people. And beyond that, hold up before them their own faults, the outward and the inward, so that the fear of the Hereafter is ignited in their chests, so that they grieve as deeply as their bones will allow over the time they have squandered, so that they strive to redeem what little may yet be redeemed, so that they weep over every hour spent without the worship and remembrance of God. This is what a sermon is for. Picture a man whose house has been struck by a flood — the water already at his door, seconds away from rushing in and drowning every soul inside. In that moment, he will cry out: *al-hadhar! al-hadhar!* — "Beware! Beware! The water is here!" He will not stop to polish his sentences, to pick out elegant turns of phrase, to garnish his warning with decorated verse. A sermon is exactly this — a cry born of real fear over one's own reckoning, carrying to other souls the same urgency that an imminent catastrophe demands.

The second thing to guard against on the pulpit is this: never let the thought slip into your heart that after your sermon the crowd will roar in praise, fall into ecstasy, tear their clothes, raise a clamor in the gathering, and declare what a marvelous sermon So-and-So gave. That thought, plainly, is *Riya* — ostentation — and to be pleased by it is proof that wisdom has not yet taken root in you. Your intention should be to summon God's creation from this world toward the next; from sin toward true servitude; from greed toward a heart unhooked from the world, content with little; from miserliness toward generosity; from showy religion toward sincerity, *Ikhlas*, where every act is performed for the Face of Allah alone; from arrogance toward humility; from heedlessness toward God-consciousness; from pride toward piety. Kindle in their hearts love for the Hereafter, so that their faces turn toward it. Loosen the grip the world has on them, so that they begin to see that attachment for what it is — an enemy standing between them and their true destination. Do not, on the other hand, lull them into a false ease

about Allah's generosity and mercy by twisting the truth to be comfortable. Cultivate in them a wakeful fear of Allah. Observe what sits in their hearts that contradicts Allah's pleasure, what they incline toward that contradicts the Shari'ah of the Prophet Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him. Watch their character and their conduct, so that the wrongs in them begin to fall away and be replaced by noble qualities and righteous deeds. For those already crushed under the weight of fear, plant hope, so that when they stand up from the gathering, certain noble virtues have been awakened in them and even their outward bearing has shifted. Those who were lazy in worship should leave inclined toward it, with a settled, deep desire for the service of God; those who were brazen in sin should leave with the fear of Allah glowing in their hearts. A sermon that does none of this — where the speaker addresses none of these matters — is a ruin for the speaker and a ruin for those who listen. Such a man is a Shaytan who, having become a slave to his own degraded self, treats the pulpit as a stage on which to display his cleverness and harvest the fame and grandeur of the world. This Shaytan leads God's creatures off the road of true guidance, sheds their blood, and pitches them headlong into eternal loss. God's creatures should keep far from him. Men like this spread a corruption — *fasad* — in the religion that even Satan himself does not spread. And whoever has the authority to remove such a man from the pulpit, the Minbar, it is obligatory upon him, *wajib*, to do so deliberately and firmly — to keep such men from preaching at all, so that they cannot go on twisting the meaning of commanding the right and forbidding the wrong, *al-amr bi'l-ma'ruf wa'n-nahy an al-munkar*.

The third thing to lay down: do not so much as greet a king, a wealthy man, or a ruler. Stay out of their company; stay out of their gatherings; and beyond even that, do not lift your eyes to look at them. In the looking, and in the keeping of their company, lie many hidden calamities.

And if by some chance you find yourself in their presence anyway, do not praise them. As a hadith tells us:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَغْضَبُ إِذَا مُدِحَ الْفَاسِقُ وَالظَّالِمُ، وَمَنْ دَعَا لِظَالِمٍ بِطُولِ الْبَقَاءِ فَقَدْ أَحَبَّ أَنْ يُعْصَى اللَّهُ فِي الْأَرْضِ

"Truly Allah is angered when the transgressor and the oppressor are praised; and whoever prays for an oppressor's long life has, in effect, loved that Allah be disobeyed upon the earth."

The fourth thing to lay down: do not accept gifts from rulers — not even when you are certain the source is lawful, *halal*. The reason is that to harbor any desire at all for their possessions does terrible damage to the *Din*, the path to God. The favors and rewards that flow from rulers are watered by oppression, transgression, and sin — and all of that erodes the *Din*. The smallest corruption that follows from accepting their gifts is that you begin to love the oppressors. And when a man loves another, he prays for that man's long life. If the oppressor lives long, the oppression lives long, and the world is more deeply troubled and more deeply corrupted — and what disaster could be greater than that? Beware! Beware! Shaytan will come at you whispering this thought: "*Take the money from the rulers, then distribute it among the poor — relieve their suffering, meet their needs.*" Beware — never accept this counsel from any Shaytan, whether from the Jinn — the unseen creation of God who, when they bend toward evil, become Satan's instruments for inciting harm among human beings — or from among human beings themselves. Do not be caught in their snares, do not be charmed by their schemes; Shaytan has shed many lives by this very strategy and goes on shedding them today. The calamities buried inside this single matter are many, and I have laid

them out at length in my *Ihya Ulum al-Din*, the Revival of the Knowledge of the Path to God. Look for them there.

So much for the four things to lay down. My dear beloved son — there are also four things to take up, and these you must attend to with care.

The first is this: every matter between you and Allah should be conducted in such a way that, if your own servant did the same for you, you would not be saddened by it — rather, you would approve of it, commend it, feel no anger at all. And likewise, whatever you would not want your servant doing to you, understand that when you yourself fall short in your servitude to your Lord, He, your Creator, is no less displeased. The truth to take to heart is this: your servant was not created by you — you only hired him. But you yourself were created, nurtured, sustained, and owned by your real Creator and Lord. You are His slave in the fullest meaning of the word. Therefore your obligation never to displease Him — by thought, by word, by deed — is greater beyond measure.

The second is this: every matter between you and the other slaves of Allah should be conducted in such a way that, if they did the same to you, you would be pleased by it and not aggrieved. As it has been said in a sacred hadith — a tradition in which Allah Himself speaks through His Prophet, peace be upon him:

لَا يَكْمُلُ إِيمَانُ عَبْدِي حَتَّى يُحِبَّ لِسَائِرِ النَّاسِ مَا يُحِبُّ لِنَفْسِهِ

"My slave's faith is not complete until he loves for all people what he loves for himself."

The third thing to take up — and I press this on you firmly — concerns your studies. If you mean to keep increasing your knowledge and to keep

working through scholarly books, then place this thought in front of you: *suppose my whole remaining life were no more than a week*. Now ask yourself, in that light, which kind of knowledge would actually serve you, and devote yourself only to that. If you knew with certainty that you had only a week left, you would not spend those last days on books of dialectical theology and disputation, on lexicography, on the niceties of grammar, on poetry and the collected diwans of poets, on the art of fine composition. You would see in an instant that none of that could help you now. You would give the whole week instead to the inward work — to the contemplation of your heart, to the recognition of the faults sitting inside your *nafs* — so that you might still make amends in the little time left. You would turn your face away from the world and its preoccupations. You would scrub your heart clean of its bad qualities. You would furnish it with the love of Allah and with noble inner virtues, and you would hand yourself over entirely to worship and servitude before Him. It is even possible that across that final week you would not visit a single person, even though you knew death might not arrive on this day, or on that night.

My dear beloved son — listen to one more thing. Remember it, hold its reality in your hands, turn it over and over in your mind, and act on it; do this, and your salvation is as good as won. If you were told that the king was coming to your house next week, you would pass the whole week consumed with one anxiety: that the king's eye should not fall on anything ugly. You would scrub everything — your body, your clothes, the walls and the floors of your house. You would leave nothing untended. Now reflect, and see for yourself. What more do I need to spell out for you in this hint? You are intelligent — a hint should be enough. This is why the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَنْظُرُ إِلَى صُورِكُمْ وَلَا إِلَى أَعْمَالِكُمْ، وَلَكِنْ يَنْظُرُ إِلَى قُلُوبِكُمْ
وَنِيَّاتِكُمْ

"Truly Allah does not look at your faces or at your outward deeds,
but He looks at your hearts and your intentions."

When the gaze of the Supreme Sovereign, *Ahkam al-Hakimin*, is resting upon your heart, why would you not purify that heart? If you wish to take up the knowledge of the matters of the heart, study my *Ihya Ulum al-Din* — "Revival of the Knowledge of the Path to God," which some have rendered as "Revival of the Religious Sciences" — along with my other works. This knowledge is personally obligatory upon every Muslim, *fard al-ayn*. The other branches of knowledge carry the lesser obligation of *fard kifaya* — a duty laid on the community as a whole, and discharged once at least one group within it has taken it up. Even that knowledge should be acquired only to the extent that you actually need it to carry out the commands of Allah, the Exalted. If Allah grants you *tawfiq* — the alignment of inward capability with inward motivation — then this knowledge of the heart is a road you must walk.

The fourth thing to take up: do not store up more than a single year's provision for your family from the goods of this world. The Prophet Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him, did set aside one year's worth of provisions for some of his wives, and said:

اللَّهُمَّ اجْعَلْ قُوتَ آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَفَافًا

"O Allah, make the provision of the family of Muhammad just enough."

Yet he did not set aside that year's portion for all of his wives, the *Azwaj al-Mutahharat*. He reserved it only for those among them whose *tawakkul*, whose reliance upon Allah, was less. For those of the Mothers of the Believers, the *Ummahat al-Mu'minin*, whose certainty in Allah was complete and whose reliance upon Him was unshakable, the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, did not set aside even a single day's provisions. Among them was A'isha al-Siddiqah, may Allah be pleased with her, and others like her among the Mothers of the Believers.

9. A Prayer for the Road

My dear beloved son — I have answered, in this book, every question you brought to me. Every door you knocked on, I have tried to open. Every knot you carried, I have tried to loosen. What remains now is not more words from me, but resolve from you. Gather it. Act upon what is here. And when you stand in the quiet places of the night, when you raise your hands and the world falls away, do not forget me in your supplications, in your *du'a*.

You asked me for one thing more. You asked me to write you a supplication you could recite always — words to keep on your tongue when the road is long and your own words fail you. Before I give you what you asked for, hear my counsel about where to look first. Go to the books of *ahadith*, the traditions of the Prophet Muhammad, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him. Go especially to the *Sahah Sitta*, the six most authenticated collections of his traditions, and search those pages as a thirsty man searches for water. What you find there, commit to memory — not to display, but to carry. And then turn to what has reached us through the *Ahl al-Bayt*, the family of the Prophet, peace and

blessings of Allah be upon him, for through them too a great river of supplication flows. Drink from both. Make their words your words.

And then, my son, recite this one after every *salah*, every prayer — let it settle into the rhythm of your days like a second heartbeat:

اللَّهُمَّ إِنِّي أَسْأَلُكَ تَمَامَ النِّعْمَةِ، وَدَوَامَ الْعَافِيَةِ، وَشُمُولَ الْعَافِيَةِ، وَالصِّحَّةَ فِي
الْبَدَنِ، وَالزِّيَادَةَ فِي الرِّزْقِ، وَالسَّعَادَةَ فِي الْعَيْشِ، وَالْفَوْزَ بِالنَّجَاحِ، وَتَمَامَ
مَكَارِمِ الْأَخْلَاقِ. اللَّهُمَّ إِنِّي أَسْأَلُكَ مِنَ الثَّوَابِ أَجْزَلَهُ، وَمِنَ الْعَطَاءِ أَهْنَاءَهُ، وَمِنَ
الْمِنْنِ أَوْفَرَهَا، وَمِنَ الْأَعْمَالِ أَحْسَنَهَا، وَمِنَ الْعِلْمِ أَنْفَعَهُ، وَمِنَ الرِّزْقِ أَطْيَبَهُ.

"O my Allah! I ask from You the fullness and perfection of Your blessings; the permanence of inward and outward well-being; the all-encompassing breadth of Your mercy and safety; soundness of body; increase in my sustenance; happiness in my life; true and lasting success; and the completion of every noble quality of character. O my Allah! I ask from Your rewards the most abundant; from Your gifts the sweetest; from Your favours the most plentiful; from all deeds the most excellent; from all knowledge the most beneficial; and from all sustenance the most wholesome."

اللَّهُمَّ كُنْ لَنَا وَلَا تَكُنْ عَلَيْنَا. اللَّهُمَّ اخْتِمِ بِالسَّعَادَةِ آجَالَنَا، وَأَصْلِحْ أَعْمَالَنَا،
وَسَلِّمْنا فِي أَيَّامِكَ وَلَيَالِيكَ، وَارْحَمْنا فِي دُورِنَا وَأَمْوَالِنَا، وَاسْتُرْ بِعَفْوِكَ ذُنُوبَنَا
وَعُيُوبَنَا، وَتَفَضَّلْ بِإِصْلَاحِ ظَوَاهِرِنَا وَبَوَاطِنِنَا، وَارْزُقْنَا النِّفَّةَ بِكَ وَالتَّوَكُّلَ
عَلَيْكَ.

"O my Allah! Be on our side and not against us — bring us benefit and let no harm pass through You to us. O my Allah! Seal our appointed lives with felicity; set our deeds in order; keep us safe through Your days and Your nights; pour Your mercy upon us in our homes and in all that we possess; veil our sins and our faults with Your forgiveness; show us the kindness of mending what is broken in us, outwardly and inwardly; and grant us confidence in You and reliance upon You."

اللَّهُمَّ ارْزُقْنَا الثَّبَاتَ فِي الدِّينِ، وَنَجِّنَا مِنْ أَعْمَالٍ تُخْزِينَا يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ، وَخَفِّفْ
عَنَّا أَوْزَارَنَا، وَارْزُقْنَا عَيْشَ السُّعْدَاءِ، وَاكْفِنَا مَا أَهَمَّنَا، وَاكْفِنَا شَرَّ الْأَشْرَارِ،
وَأَعْتِقْنَا وَأَبَاءَنَا مِنَ النَّارِ وَمِنَ الدَّيْنِ وَالظُّلْمِ، يَا عَزِيزُ، يَا غَفَّارُ، يَا كَرِيمُ، يَا
سَتَّارُ، يَا حَلِيمُ، يَا جَبَّارُ، يَا عَظِيمُ، يَا قَهَّارُ. اللَّهُ، اللَّهُ، اللَّهُ، يَا رَحْمَنُ الدُّنْيَا، يَا
رَحِيمَ الْآخِرَةِ، يَا أَرْحَمَ الرَّاحِمِينَ، أَنْتَ صَاحِبُ الرَّحْمَةِ الْوَاسِعَةِ. وَصَلَّى اللَّهُ
عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ خَيْرِ خَلْقِهِ أَجْمَعِينَ مِنَ الْأَزَلِ إِلَى الْأَبَدِ، وَعَلَى آلِهِ وَأَصْحَابِهِ،
وَالْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ.

"O my Allah! Grant us steadfastness and perseverance in our *din*,
our religion and our road to You. Save us from deeds in this world
that would become a source of shame and humiliation for us on the
Day of Judgement. Lighten the burden of our sins. Grant us the life
of the pious. Be sufficient for us in all our affairs, and protect us
from the evil of the evildoers. Liberate us and our forebears from
the Fire of Hell, from debt, and from oppression. O You the
Victorious One, *Ya Aziz*! O You the Forgiving One, *Ya Ghaffar*! O You
the Generous One, *Ya Karim*! O You the Coverer of Faults, *Ya Sattar*!
O You the Forbearing One, *Ya Halim*! O You the Compeller, *Ya
Jabbar*! O You the Magnificent One, *Ya Azim*! O You Who Subdues
all things, *Ya Qahhar*! O Allah! O Allah! O Allah! O You the
Compassionate One in this world, *Ya Rahman*! O You the Merciful
One in the life hereafter, *Ya Rahim*! O You the Greatest of the
Merciful, *Ya Arhama ar-Rahimin* — You are the Granter of boundless
mercy. And may the mercy and blessings of Allah descend always
upon Muhammad, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, the
finest of all creation from eternity to eternity, and upon his

descendants, and upon his companions. All praise belongs solely to Allah, the Lord of all the Universes, *Rabb ul-Alamin*."

Carry this with you, my son. Say it slowly. Let each phrase land before you reach for the next. A supplication recited in haste is a letter dropped at the door without ever being read; a supplication recited with presence is a conversation with the One who is nearer to you than your own jugular vein.

And here, at this last threshold, I lay down my pen. Everything I had to give you, I have given. Everything I withheld, I withheld because it is for you to find on your own road. What remains is between you and your Lord. Walk well. Walk in the company of those whose hearts He has already turned. And when the road grows long and the night grows cold, remember that the One who set you on this path has never once abandoned a traveller who kept calling His name.

This book comes to an end with the help of *al-Malik*, the Absolute Sovereign, and *al-Wahhab*, the Giver of all.